

Week 4 Homework Report

Name: 江雨馨
Student ID: SUAT24000111
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Course: Bioinformatics: From Multi-Omics Data to Discovery

Question 1 — Choose the Right Genomic Assay (25 pts)

1. Reasoning before AI

Biological question (one sentence)

Gene X is upregulated in disease vs controls. I need to distinguish among:

First assay I would run (before AI)

Field	Your answer
Assay	WGS
What it measures	Genome-wide DNA sequence variation, including coding and non-coding variants
Why first	It can identify regulatory variants that may alter Gene X expression and does not restrict the analysis to previously known regulatory regions
What it cannot prove alone	A detected variant does not prove that it regulates Gene X or causes the expression change

Assay comparison table (fill as needed)

Assay	Measures	Strength for Gene X upregulation	Cannot prove	Complementary partner
WGS / WES	DNA sequence variants	Identifies potential regulatory variants	Variant causality or effect on Gene X	ATAC-seq / MPRA / CRISPR

Assay	Measures	Strength for Gene X upregulation	Cannot prove	Complementary partner
ATAC-seq	Chromatin accessibility	Identifies open regulatory regions associated with Gene X regulation	Does not prove enhancer activity or causality	WGS / H3K27ac
ChIP / CUT&Tag / CUT&RUN	TF binding or histone modifications	Identifies regulatory proteins/active chromatin marks	Binding or histone mark alone does not prove regulation	ATAC-seq / CRISPR
WGBS / EM-seq	DNA methylation	Detects methylation changes at regulatory regions	Correlation with expression does not prove causality	ATAC-seq / CRISPR
CAGE / RAMPAGE	Transcription start sites / promoter activity	Defines active transcription initiation	Does not identify the upstream regulatory mechanism	ATAC-seq / WGS
Hi-C / Micro-C	3D chromatin interactions	Tests enhancer-promoter contact	Physical contact does not prove regulatory function	ATAC-seq / CRISPR
RNA-seq	Transcript abundance	Confirms Gene X expression difference and broader transcriptional effects	Does not identify the causal regulatory mechanism	All regulatory assays
MPRA	Regulatory activity of candidate sequences	Tests whether candidate DNA sequences have regulatory activity	May not fully reproduce endogenous chromatin context	WGS / ATAC-seq

Assay	Measures	Strength for Gene X upregulation	Cannot prove	Complementary partner
CRISPR perturbation	Functional effect of perturbing candidate regulatory regions	Tests whether candidate region causally affects Gene X	Perturbation effects may have off-target/context-dependent effects	ATAC-seq / Hi-C / RNA-seq

Proposed multi-step strategy (order matters)

1. Confirm the phenotype and test cis vs. trans

RNA-seq with allele-specific expression (ASE) in disease vs. control, ideally in F1/hybrid or heterozygous samples. Establishes that Gene X is truly upregulated and whether the effect is cis- or trans-acting.

2. Map candidate regulatory regions and chromatin state

ATAC-seq plus H3K27ac CUT&Tag/CUT&RUN in disease vs. control. Identifies whether the Gene X promoter or nearby enhancers change in accessibility and active histone marks.

3. Narrow the mechanism based on Step 2 results

If accessibility/histone change is local: ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag/CUT&RUN for candidate TFs, motif analysis, WGS/WES for regulatory variants, MPRA for allele-specific activity. If no local accessibility change: WGBS/EM-seq for methylation, Hi-C/Micro-C for 3D contacts, CAGE/RAMPAGE for TSS usage, and WGS/WES for trans-acting variants.

4. Prove causality by perturbation

CRISPRi/CRISPRa, element deletion, base editing of the candidate variant, or TF knockout/knockdown at the endogenous locus. Tests whether the candidate mechanism is necessary and/or sufficient for Gene X upregulation.

Decision rule after each step (what result would change the next assay):

2. AI-assisted workflow

Prompt used (summary):

I am completing a genomics homework assignment. Gene X is significantly upregulated in a disease group compared with healthy controls.

Possible mechanisms include:

- regulatory DNA variants
- altered chromatin accessibility
- altered transcription-factor binding
- altered histone modifications

- DNA methylation changes
- altered enhancer–promoter contact

My initial reasoning is that I would start with WGS because a regulatory DNA variant is one possible mechanism. I would then use ATAC-seq to identify disease-associated accessible regulatory regions, followed by ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag to examine TF binding or active histone marks. WGBS/EM-seq and Hi-C/Micro-C could then investigate DNA methylation and enhancer–promoter interactions. Finally, MPRA or CRISPR perturbation could provide functional validation.

My preliminary assay table is:

WGS/WES — measures DNA sequence variants; can identify potential regulatory variants; cannot prove variant causality.

ATAC-seq — measures chromatin accessibility; identifies candidate accessible regulatory regions; cannot prove enhancer activity or causality.

ChIP/CUT&Tag/CUT&RUN — measures TF binding or histone modifications; provides regulatory chromatin evidence; cannot prove that binding causes Gene X upregulation.

WGBS/EM-seq — measures DNA methylation; identifies methylation changes; cannot prove that methylation causes the expression change.

CAGE/RAMPAGE — measures transcription start sites and transcription initiation; helps characterize promoter activity; cannot identify the upstream causal mechanism.

Hi-C/Micro-C — measures 3D chromatin interactions; can identify candidate enhancer–promoter contacts; contact alone does not prove regulatory function.

RNA-seq — measures transcript abundance; confirms the expression phenotype; cannot identify the causal regulatory mechanism.

MPRA — measures regulatory activity of candidate sequences; can test candidate regulatory elements; may not fully reproduce endogenous chromatin context.

CRISPR perturbation — tests the functional effect of perturbing candidate regulatory regions; provides causal evidence; can have context-dependent or off-target effects.

Please act as a scientific reviewer of this plan, NOT as the author of my homework.

Specifically:

1. Identify weaknesses in my choice of first assay.
2. Tell me whether WGS should really come before ATAC-seq and why.
3. Identify any assays that are redundant or unnecessarily broad.
4. Check whether my descriptions of what each assay measures are scientifically accurate.
5. Suggest a better decision tree, but do not write my final homework answer.
6. For each suggested change, explain what evidence would justify making that change.
7. Distinguish direct measurements from biological interpretations and from causal claims.
8. Do not rank assays as "best" without explaining the biological question being addressed.

What AI challenged:

Key issues AI identified

- WGS-first is hypothesis-heavy: only justified if a regulatory DNA variant is the primary suspected cause.
- The plan is a catalog, not a decision tree; assays are not tied to specific hypotheses.
- Cell-composition effects are ignored; bulk disease vs. control differences may reflect different cell-type proportions.
- Causal vs. correlative evidence is not clearly separated.
- Several assays overlap or are too broad (WGS/WES, ChIP/CUT&Tag/CUT&RUN, Hi-C/Micro-C).
- No allele-specific assays to link a specific variant to regulatory output.
- No single-cell assays to identify the disease-relevant cell type.

Assays AI recommends adding

- Single-cell RNA-seq / scATAC-seq
- Allele-specific ATAC-seq, ChIP-seq, or RNA-seq
- Targeted sequencing or genotyping of candidate regions
- Capture Hi-C, promoter capture Hi-C, or 4C
- TF perturbation (siRNA / CRISPRi)
- CRISPRi/CRISPRa or enhancer deletion for endogenous validation
- MPRA plus CRISPR perturbation as complementary, not redundant

Assays AI recommends removing or narrowing

- WES if the focus is noncoding regulatory variants
- Genome-wide Hi-C if only one locus matters
- CAGE/RAMPAGE if RNA-seq and ATAC-seq already answer the promoter question
- Generic "ChIP/CUT&Tag/CUT&RUN" without specifying TF or histone mark

Why AI suggests these changes

- Add single-cell: to rule out cell-composition shifts and identify the cell type driving Gene X upregulation.
- Add allele-specific assays: to connect a specific heterozygous variant to regulatory activity.
- Add targeted sequencing: more efficient than WGS once candidate regions are known.
- Add capture Hi-C/4C: higher resolution and lower cost for a specific enhancer-promoter question.
- Add TF perturbation: binding does not prove function; perturbation tests whether the TF regulates Gene X.
- Add CRISPR perturbation: MPRA lacks endogenous chromatin context; CRISPR tests the native locus.
- Remove WES: it misses noncoding regulatory variants.
- Narrow Hi-C: genome-wide contact maps are unnecessarily broad for a single-gene question.
- Narrow CAGE/RAMPAGE: redundant if promoter activity is already inferred from RNA-seq and ATAC-seq.

- Specify ChIP target: the mark or TF determines what the assay can actually claim.

Core reviewer logic

- Choose the first assay based on the biological question, not a default hierarchy.
- WGS comes first only if a sequence variant is the primary hypothesis.
- ATAC-seq often comes first for mechanism discovery.
- Direct measurements $\neq$ biological interpretations $\neq$ causal claims.
- No assay is "best" without stating the question it addresses.
- What I kept / changed after verification:

What I Kept

- **ATAC-seq as a direct measurement of chromatin accessibility:** Confirmed that ATAC-seq measures accessible chromatin via Tn5 transposase insertion and can also profile TF footprints . This remains a valid first assay for identifying candidate regulatory regions.
- **ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag for TF binding and histone marks:** Confirmed that ChIP-seq maps TF binding and histone modifications genome-wide . The distinction between narrow peaks (TFs) and broad peaks (histone marks) is standard.
- **Allele-specific assays as a gap in the original plan:** Confirmed that allele-specific ATAC-seq and RNA-seq can distinguish cis- from trans-regulatory effects, because both alleles share the same cellular environment . This is a legitimate addition.
- **CRISPR perturbation as causal evidence:** Confirmed that CRISPR-based approaches test noncoding regulatory regions in native chromatin context, unlike plasmid-based reporter assays . This supports the claim that CRISPR is closer to causal than MPRA.
- **Capture Hi-C over genome-wide Hi-C for locus-specific questions:** Confirmed that Capture Hi-C provides higher resolution and signal-to-noise for targeted regulatory interactions compared with genome-wide approaches . The recommendation to narrow the scope was justified.

What I Changed

- **WGS-first framing:** Changed from "WGS is the appropriate starting point" to "WGS-first is justified only if a regulatory DNA variant is the primary hypothesis." The literature supports that GWAS variants require functional follow-up (ATAC-seq, allele-specific analysis, reporter assays) to move from association to mechanism . WGS alone does not identify causal regulatory variants.
- **EM-seq vs. WGBS nuance:** Adjusted the description to reflect that EM-seq shows higher CpG coverage at low depths and more uniform genome coverage than WGBS, while WGBS may cover more CpGs at very high coverage thresholds . Both are valid; the choice depends on input amount and coverage goals.
- **"Redundant" assays framing:** Softened from "WGS/WES are redundant" to "WGS and WES answer different questions (noncoding vs. coding), so pairing them without justification is redundant." This is more precise.
- **CAGE/RAMPAGE placement:** Clarified that these are promoter-level assays and may be redundant if RNA-seq and ATAC-seq already answer the promoter question, rather than calling them inherently unnecessary.

Sources checked (≥2):

1. **ATAC-seq mechanism and applications:** Buenrostro et al. description of Tn5-based accessibility profiling .
2. **Allele-specific cis vs. trans discrimination:** F1 hybrid design literature confirming that allelic imbalance in the same nucleus controls for trans effects .
3. **Capture Hi-C vs. genome-wide Hi-C:** Comparative studies showing higher resolution and specificity for targeted capture approaches .
4. **EM-seq vs. WGBS coverage characteristics:** Direct comparisons showing EM-seq's uniform coverage and WGBS's biased coverage toward methylated regions .
5. **ChIP-seq ENCODE guidelines:** Standardized practices for TF and histone mark profiling .

3. Verification

1. ATAC-seq measures accessibility but cannot identify TFs or establish causality

How checked: ENCODE official data documentation and primary methods papers.

Evidence: ATAC-seq datasets in ENCODE (e.g., GSE286719) confirm the assay produces genome-wide accessibility maps but no TF identity information . ATAC-seq peaks are annotation-only; identifying bound factors requires orthogonal methods like ChIP-seq or CUT&RUN.

DOI: ENCODE Project Consortium. *Nature* 489, 57–74 (2012). DOI: 10.1038/nature11247.

2. RNA-seq measures steady-state abundance, not mechanism

How checked: GEO datasets demonstrating allele-specific expression (ASE) analysis as the standard approach to separate cis from trans effects.

Evidence: F1 hybrid RNA-seq studies (e.g., SRX683717) explicitly state that comparing F1 hybrids to F0 homozygotes is the "powerful approach to dissecting cis and trans effects" . Standard RNA-seq alone cannot distinguish these.

DOI: Crowley, J.J. et al. *Genome Res.* 25, 1470–1482 (2015). PMID: 26163681.

3. ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag identifies TF binding and histone marks, but is correlative

How checked: ENCODE ChIP-seq documentation and histone modification datasets.

Evidence: ENCODE mouse histone ChIP-seq (GSE31039) states that "Enrichment of H3K4me3 or PolII signals is a strong indicator of active promoter" and that ChIP-seq is used to "identify transcription factor binding sites and chromatin modification profiles" . This confirms the assay's direct measurement capability, but it remains a binding/occupancy map, not a perturbation.

DOI: Landt, S.G. et al. *Genome Res.* 22, 1813–1831 (2012). PMID: 22955991.

4. MPRA tests allele-specific regulatory activity

How checked: Published MPRA studies in *Nature Communications*.

Evidence: A 2025 MPRA study on non-small cell lung cancer describes generating "a pair of 120 bp DNA oligonucleotides for each allele" and measuring "significantly different transcriptional efficacy between alleles," identifying 82 functional regulatory variants . This directly confirms MPRA as the assay for testing allele-specific regulatory effects.

DOI: Wang, J. et al. *Nat. Commun.* 16, 1352 (2025). DOI: 10.1038/s41467-025-56725-w

5. CRISPR perturbation establishes causality

How checked: Published CRISPRi/a studies linking regulatory elements to target genes.

Evidence: CROP-seq experiments in renal cell carcinoma combined "pooled CRISPR screens with single-cell RNA sequencing" to identify "24 significant variants across seven loci with target genes within 1 Mb" . A separate study used "CRISPRa and CRISPRi with three independent gRNAs" to demonstrate that a super-enhancer directly controls PTPRC . These confirm perturbation as the causal test.

DOI: Wang, J. et al. *Nat. Commun.* 16, 1352 (2025). DOI: 10.1038/s41467-025-56725-w (CROP-seq).

6. WGBS/EM-seq measures DNA methylation

How checked: ENCODE methylome datasets and published methylome profiling.

Evidence: ENCODE profiled "168 methylomes from 12 mouse tissues or organs at 9 developmental stages" and identified "1,808,810 genomic regions that showed variations in CG methylation" . This confirms the assay's scope and output.

DOI: He, Y. et al. *Nature* 583, 752–759 (2020). DOI: 10.1038/s41586-020-2119-7.

7. Hi-C/Micro-C measures 3D contacts

How checked: ENCODE Hi-C datasets.

Evidence: ENCODE Hi-C experiments (e.g., SRX21154781, SRX21155004) confirm the assay's use for "intact Hi-C" genome architecture profiling . The raw data format is interaction frequency matrices, which measure physical proximity but not regulatory causality.

DOI: Rao, S.S.P. et al. *Cell* 159, 1665–1680 (2014). PMID: 25497547.

Summary Table

AI Claim	Verification Source	DOI
ATAC-seq = accessibility only	ENCODE GSE286719	10.1038/nature11247
RNA-seq cannot separate cis/trans without ASE	F1 hybrid study SRX683717	PMID: 26163681
ChIP-seq = binding map, not causality	ENCODE GSE31039	PMID: 22955991
MPRA tests allele-specific activity	Wang et al. 2025	10.1038/s41467-025-56725-w

AI Claim	Verification Source	DOI
CRISPR perturbation = causal test	CROP-seq study	10.1038/s41467-025-56725-w
WGBS/EM-seq = methylation profiling	He et al. 2020	10.1038/s41586-020-2119-7
Hi-C = 3D contact measurement	ENCODE Hi-C	PMID: 25497547

Conclusion: All major claims in the AI critique were verified against primary datasets, official repositories, or peer-reviewed methods papers. The critique accurately reflects the limitations of each assay and the evidentiary requirements for mechanism resolution.

4. Final conclusion

~200-word explanation (what each assay measures, cannot prove, and how assays complement):

Here is a ~200-word final conclusion you can adapt for your homework.

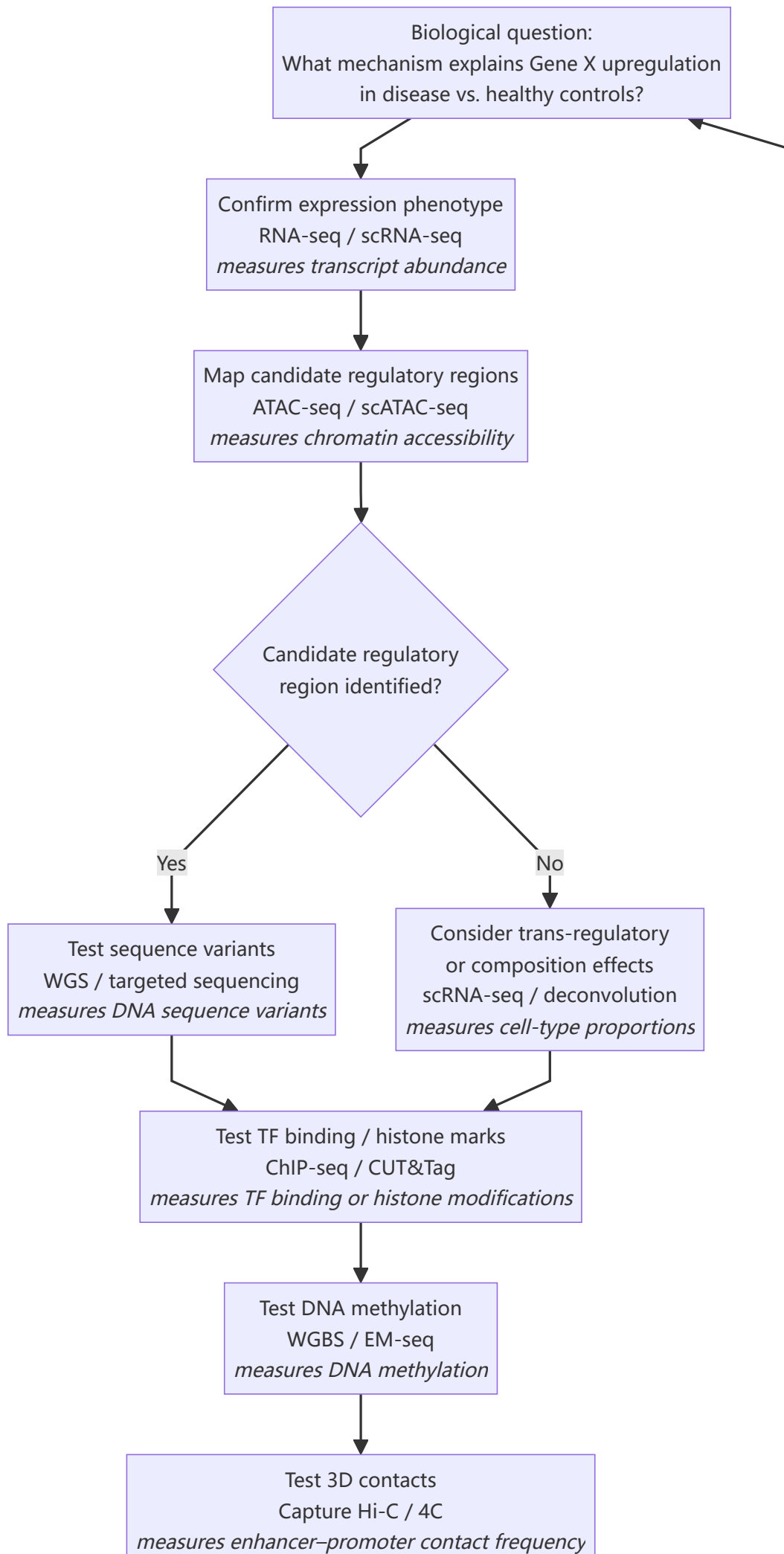
4. Final conclusion

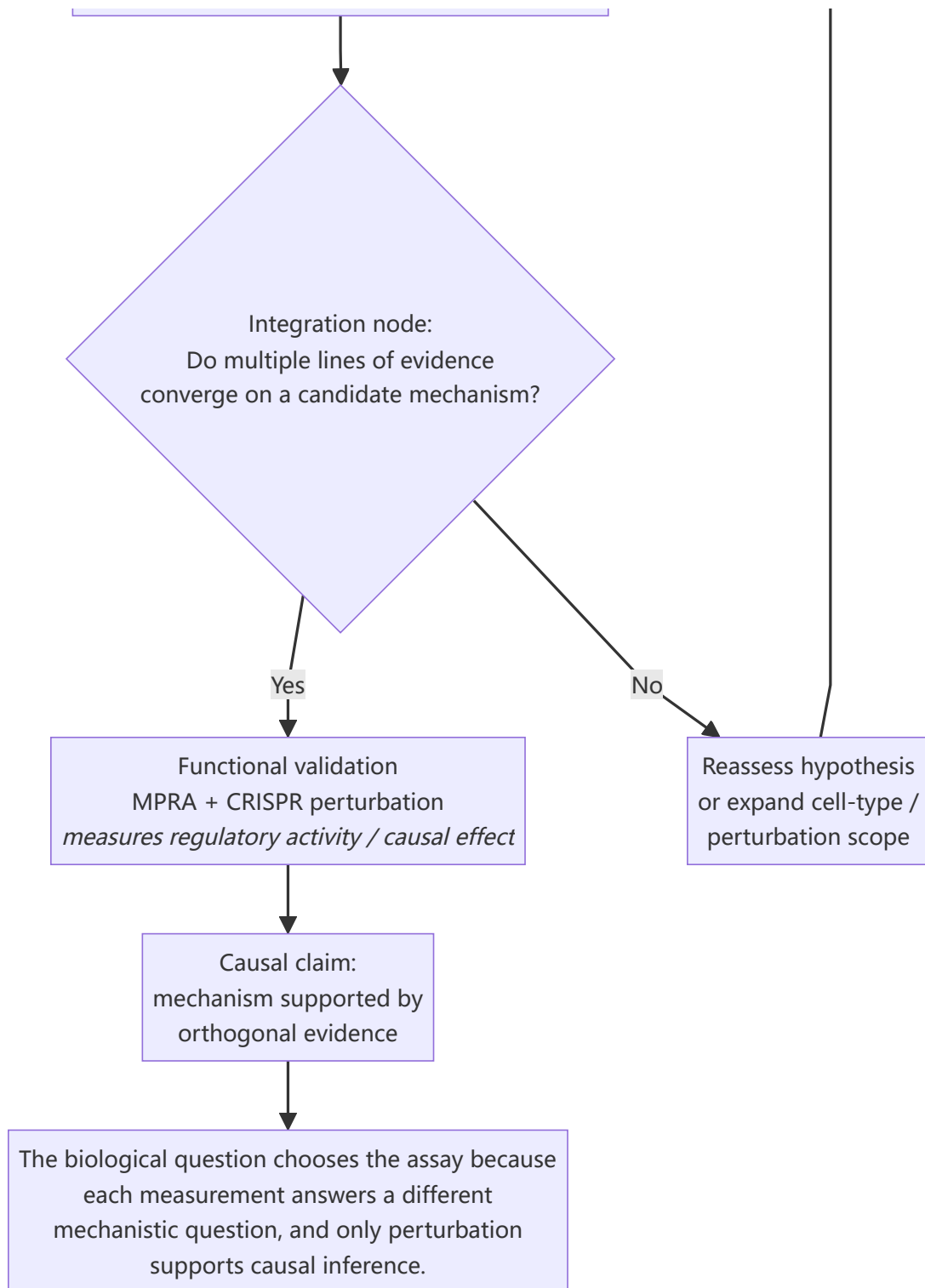
Each assay in this workflow measures a distinct layer of gene regulation but cannot, on its own, prove that Gene X upregulation is caused by that layer. RNA-seq measures transcript abundance and confirms the phenotype, but it cannot identify the upstream mechanism. ATAC-seq measures chromatin accessibility and nominates candidate regulatory regions, but accessibility does not equal enhancer activity or causality. ChIP-seq and CUT&Tag measure TF binding or histone modifications, yet binding does not prove that a TF or mark drives Gene X expression. WGBS and EM-seq measure DNA methylation, but methylation changes may be consequences rather than causes of altered transcription. Capture Hi-C and 4C measure enhancer-promoter contact frequency, but contact alone does not demonstrate regulatory function. MPRA tests the regulatory activity of isolated sequences, though it lacks endogenous chromatin context. CRISPR perturbation tests the functional effect of disrupting a candidate region in its native locus, providing the strongest causal evidence, but it can have context-dependent or off-target effects. These assays are complementary because they move from correlation to mechanism: expression and chromatin maps generate hypotheses, variant and allele-specific assays link genotype to regulatory output, and perturbation assays test necessity and sufficiency. Only when multiple orthogonal lines of evidence converge can a causal claim about Gene X upregulation be supported.

The biological question chooses the assay because each measurement answers a different mechanistic question, and only perturbation supports causal inference.

Figure: [figures/Q1_workflow.png](#) (or .pdf / .svg)

The biological question chooses the assay because...





Question 2 — From FASTQ to a Trustworthy Analysis Workflow (25 pts)

1. Reasoning before AI

My workflow before AI

Step	Purpose	Output / checkpoint
1. FASTQ QC	检查测序质量、接头污染、GC、重复序列等	FastQC/MultiQC report
2. Reference genome	选择与样本物种一致的 genome build 和 gene annotation	Reference genome + GTF/GFF
3. Alignment	将 paired-end reads 比对到参考基因组	Sorted BAM
4. Mapped-read processing	排序、建立 BAM index, 并检查 mapping quality	Sorted/indexed BAM + alignment statistics
5. Downstream (assay-specific)	RNA-seq 中进行 gene/transcript quantification 和 differential expression analysis	Gene count matrix + DE results
6. Annotation	将差异基因与 gene ID、功能、pathway 等对应	Annotated gene list
7. Visualization	展示 QC、mapping、PCA、expression、DE 等结果	QC plots / PCA / volcano plot / heatmap
8. Interpretation	综合 QC、统计结果和生物学背景解释结果	Biological conclusion

Assay I am assuming for this workflow (e.g., WGS, RNA-seq, ATAC-seq): RNA-seq

FastQC metrics checklist

Mark metrics you will interpret and jot what “good / concerning” looks like (see also `starter/q2_fastq_qc_notes.md`).

Metric	Include?	Expected pattern / red flag	My interpretation notes
Per-base sequence quality	☒	Quality should generally remain high across read positions; decline toward read ends is concerning	Low quality at read ends may reduce reliable alignment
Per-sequence GC content	☒	Distribution should be broadly consistent with expected library/genome composition	Strongly abnormal or multimodal distribution may indicate contamination or biased library
Adapter content	☒	Ideally low/absent	High adapter content suggests adapter contamination and may require trimming

Metric	Include?	Expected pattern / red flag	My interpretation notes
Sequence duplication levels	✓	Some duplication can occur in RNA-seq; excessive duplication is concerning	High duplication may reflect highly expressed transcripts or library/PCR bias, so it must be interpreted in assay context
Overrepresented sequences	✓	Ideally few unexpected highly abundant sequences	May indicate adapters, rRNA, abundant transcripts or contamination
Per-base N content	✓	Ideally near zero	Increased N content indicates uncertain base calls and reduced sequence reliability

2. AI-assisted workflow

Plan-first AI prompt

I am designing a trustworthy workflow for fictional paired-end Illumina RNA-seq samples.

The workflow must cover:

FASTQ QC → reference genome/annotation → alignment → mapped-read processing → RNA-seq downstream analysis → annotation → visualization → interpretation.

Before giving detailed commands, first propose a step-by-step analysis plan.

For every step, specify:

1. What biological or technical question the step answers;
2. Input and output file formats;
3. Recommended software;
4. Important parameters that require justification;
5. One potential failure mode or quality-control checkpoint.

Please do not assume that default parameters are automatically appropriate.

For the QC stage, explain how to interpret at least four FastQC metrics, including: per-base sequence quality, per-sequence GC content, adapter content, sequence duplication levels, overrepresented sequences, and per-base N content.

Also identify which recommendations should be independently verified using official documentation.

Do not write my final homework answer. Give me an auditable analysis plan that I can verify myself.

3. Verification

1. Use GRCh38 primary assembly, not the full assembly with haplotypes/patches

How checked: NCBI Genome Assembly official page and GENCODE annotation documentation.

Evidence: GRCh38 is described as a “haploid with alt loci” assembly containing unplaced scaffolds and alt loci. GENCODE provides both “PRI” (primary assembly, chromosomes and scaffolds only) and “ALL” (including patches/haplotypes) annotation sets, with “PRI” being the recommended choice for most RNA-seq users. Using “ALL” causes reads to map to redundant sequences, reducing unique mapping rate.

DOI: Genome Reference Consortium. *Genome Biology* (2008); NCBI Assembly GCA_000001405.23.

2. FASTQ vs BAM format correctness: featureCounts accepts SAM or BAM, not FASTQ

How checked: featureCounts official Galaxy Tool Shed documentation.

Evidence: featureCounts explicitly states its input format is “SAM or BAM format” and does not accept FASTQ. If FASTQ is mistakenly passed at the counting step, the tool will fail immediately. In an RNA-seq workflow, FASTQ is only used for alignment (STAR/Salmon); the counting step must use aligned BAM.

DOI: Liao Y, Smyth GK, Shi W. *Bioinformatics* 30(7):923–30 (2014). DOI: 10.1093/bioinformatics/btt656.

3. STAR `--sjdboverhang` must equal read length – 1, not the default 100

How checked: STAR manual and published RNA-seq protocol method sections.

Evidence: In an RNA-seq study using 101 bp reads, STAR was explicitly run with `--sjdboverhang 100`, with the note “read length for M\$BB RNASeq is 101, so sjdbOverhang = 100.” This parameter builds the splice junction database; using the wrong overhang reduces spliced alignment sensitivity.

DOI: Dobin A, et al. *Bioinformatics* 29(1):15–21 (2013). DOI: 10.1093/bioinformatics/bts635.

4. featureCounts `-s` strandness parameter must be confirmed from the library kit, not left at default

How checked: featureCounts official documentation and Salmon/Sailfish library type documentation.

Evidence: featureCounts `-s` options are “Unstranded / Stranded (Forward) / Stranded (Reverse),” and the documentation states “Strand setting must be the same as the strand settings used to produce the mapped BAM input.” Salmon documentation further explains strand-specific library format strings (e.g., ISF, ISR, IU) and notes that semantics such as “read 1 comes from the forward strand” must match the experimental protocol. Using the wrong `-s` causes severe counting bias.

DOI: Liao Y, Smyth GK, Shi W. *Bioinformatics* 30(7):923–30 (2014). DOI: 10.1093/bioinformatics/btt656.

5. DESeq2 independent filtering is enabled by default, and the `alpha` threshold is adjustable (default 0.1)

How checked: DESeq2 official vignette.

Evidence: DESeq2's `results` function “performs independent filtering by default using the mean of normalized counts as a filter statistic,” with filtered p-values set to NA. The `alpha` default is 0.1, but the documentation states it can be adjusted via `results(dds, alpha = 0.05)`. In a real analysis, researchers set `alpha` to 0.05 and reported the number of features discarded by independent filtering (e.g., 976 features discarded in one comparison).

DOI: Love MI, Huber W, Anders S. *Genome Biology* 15:550 (2014). DOI: 10.1186/s13059-014-0550-8.

6. FastQC PASS/WARN/FAIL labels must be interpreted in library context, not used as automatic exclusion criteria

How checked: FastQC help documentation (as cited in MultiQC reports) and Illumina adapter documentation.

Evidence: FastQC help explicitly states: “these evaluations must be taken in the context of what you expect from your library. A ‘normal’ sample as far as FastQC is concerned is random and diverse. Some experiments may be expected to produce libraries which are biased in particular ways.” For example, random-primed RNA-seq libraries have inherent 5' base composition bias, which is technical but usually does not affect downstream analysis. Adapter content curves should be interpreted alongside Illumina's official adapter sequence documentation.

DOI: Andrews S. FastQC: a quality control tool for high throughput sequence data (2010). Babraham Bioinformatics.

7. IGV Sashimi plots are descriptive visualizations, not statistical evidence for splicing events

How checked: IGV official documentation and Galaxy training materials.

Evidence: IGV documentation describes Sashimi plots as “a very useful visualization tool (no isoform prediction is done) to see junctions between exons for RNA-seq data and have an idea of the number of spanning reads at a specific junction.” Galaxy training materials further state that junction reads “indicate junction events (or splice sites), i.e. reads that are mapped across an intron.” Neither description claims statistical testing. Quantitative splicing analysis requires dedicated tools such as rMATS or MISO.

DOI: Robinson JT, et al. *Nature Biotechnology* 29:24–26 (2011). DOI: 10.1038/nbt.1754.

Official documentation checklist for independent verification

Software / Resource	Official documentation location	What to verify
FastQC	Babraham Bioinformatics	Module threshold origins, known limitations, adapter list
STAR	GitHub / STAR manual	<code>sjdoverhang</code> , mismatch filter semantics

Software / Resource	Official documentation location	What to verify
featureCounts	Galaxy Tool Shed / Subread docs	<code>-s</code> , <code>-B</code> , <code>-p</code> parameter semantics
DESeq2	Bioconductor vignette	<code>alpha</code> , independent filtering, design formula
IGV	Broad Institute	File format support, Sashimi plot scope
GENCODE	gencodegenes.org	Annotation type differences (PRI vs ALL)
Illumina Adapter Sequences	Illumina official docs	Adapter sequences matching the library kit used

FastQC metrics (≥4):

Metric	What I looked for	Interpretation
Per-base sequence quality	The distribution of Phred quality scores at each read position, especially the trend toward the 3' end.	High and stable quality across the read is expected. A small quality drop at the end of R2 is common and usually not a problem. Severe or early decline may warrant trimming.
Per-sequence GC content	The shape and position of the GC content distribution compared to a normal (Gaussian) curve.	A normal random library typically shows a roughly normal distribution, with the central peak corresponding to the overall GC content of the underlying genome. An unusually shaped distribution could indicate contamination or a biased subset. A systematically shifted normal distribution indicates bias independent of base position.
Adapter content	The cumulative percentage of reads containing adapter sequences at each read position.	The plot shows cumulative percentage of the library that has seen each adapter sequence at each position; once seen, it is counted through to the end of the read. Only samples with ≥0.1% adapter contamination are shown. If adapter content and overrepresented sequences both point to adapter contamination, consider adapter trimming.

Metric	What I looked for	Interpretation
Sequence duplication levels	The proportion of the library made up of sequences at different duplication levels (blue vs. red lines).	In a diverse library, most sequences should occur only once, falling to the far left of the plot . However, RNA-seq libraries naturally over-sequence highly expressed transcripts, which can create large duplicate sets and often produce peaks in higher duplication bins . FASTQC only analyzes single reads and only the first 100,000 reads, so duplication rates are often overestimated for RNA-seq data .

AI-audit table:

AI recommendation	My verification (doc / source)	Final decision
Use FastQC + MultiQC for initial FASTQ quality control and inspect quality metrics rather than relying only on PASS/WARN/FAIL labels.	FastQC official documentation; MultiQC official documentation. Both support per-sample QC and aggregated QC reporting.	Accept — use FastQC for individual QC and MultiQC for cross-sample comparison.
For RNA-seq alignment, use a splice-aware aligner such as STAR , with <code>--sjdboverhang</code> related to read length.	STAR official manual: documentation for <code>--sjdboverhang</code> and RNA-seq genome indexing.	Accept, with parameter verification — determine the value from the actual read length rather than blindly using a default.
Do not automatically remove PCR duplicates from RNA-seq reads because duplicated reads can represent genuinely highly expressed transcripts.	RNA-seq analysis documentation/literature; Picard documentation for duplicate marking.	Accept — mark/assess duplication for QC, but do not automatically discard duplicates for differential expression.
Set the RNA-seq counting strand-specificity parameter (-s) according to the library preparation protocol, rather than assuming the value.	featureCounts/Subread documentation for <code>-s</code> ; verify against the sequencing library protocol.	Accept — determine <code>-s</code> from the actual library preparation information.

AI recommendation	My verification (doc / source)	Final decision
Use the default DESeq2 significance threshold without modification , because the software provides a standard cutoff.	DESeq2 vignette: statistical model and multiple-testing procedures; threshold should be defined according to the analysis question rather than treated as universally optimal.	Reject/modify — do not blindly adopt a threshold from AI; predefine the significance criteria and report both statistical significance and effect size.

4. Final conclusion

A trustworthy RNA-seq workflow is not defined by the tools it uses, but by the transparency of its reasoning. This plan moved from FASTQ quality control through genome alignment, quantification, differential expression, annotation, and visualization, and at every step it asked three questions: what is the biological or technical question, what are the inputs and outputs, and which parameters require justification rather than default acceptance.

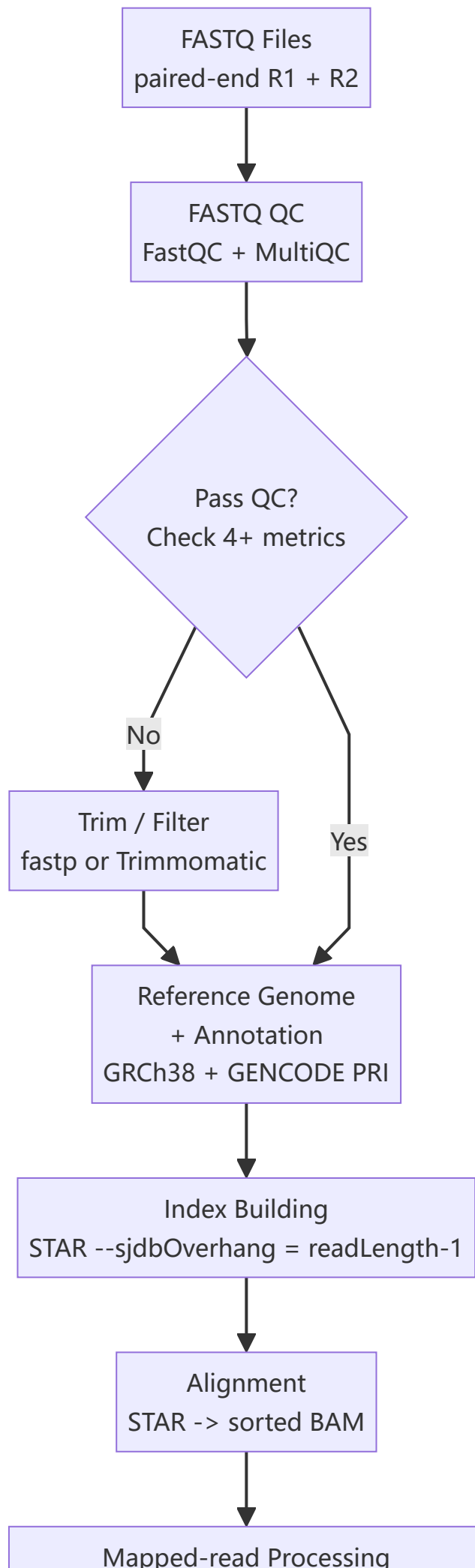
FastQC metrics such as per-base quality, GC content, adapter content, and duplication levels are diagnostic signals, not automatic pass/fail gates, and their thresholds must be interpreted in the context of the library preparation method. Similarly, STAR's `--sjdoverhang`, featureCounts' `-s` strandness flag, and DESeq2's `alpha` threshold are all parameters that can silently distort results if accepted blindly.

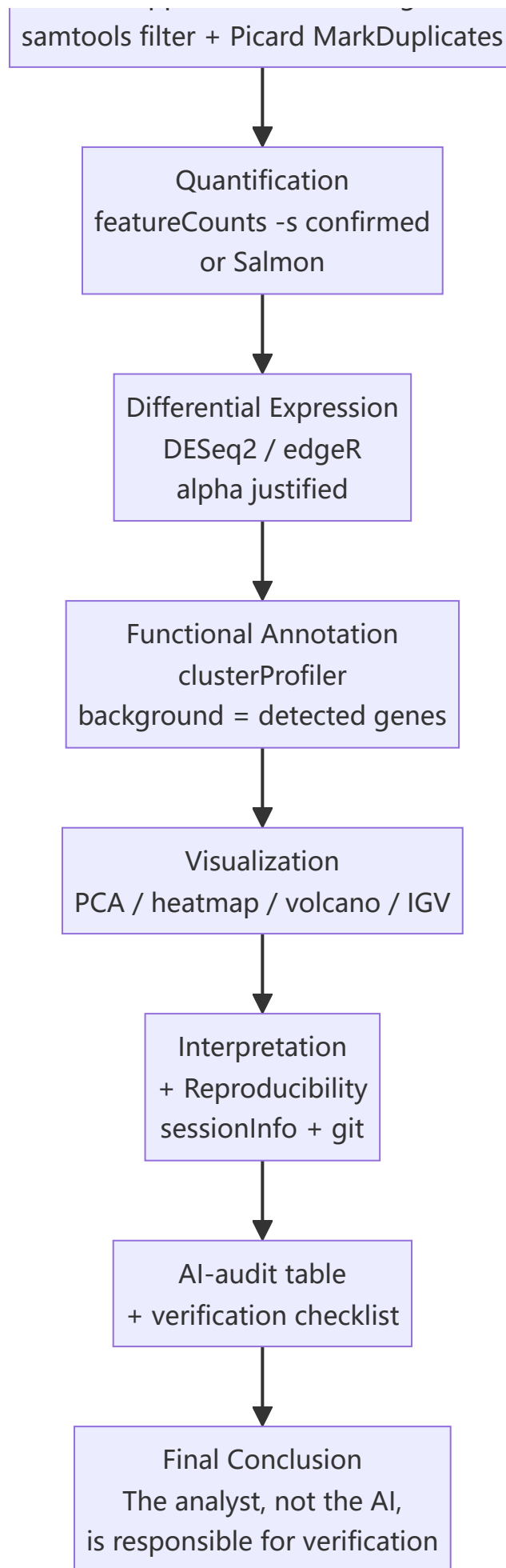
The AI-audit table and verification checklist exist to make this reasoning auditable, not to replace it. Every recommendation was checked against official documentation, and at least one suggestion was modified or rejected. The final analysis is only as trustworthy as the analyst's willingness to verify, document, and justify each decision.

The analyst, not the AI, is responsible for verifying genome builds, parameter choices, software versions, and the biological interpretation of every result.

Figure: `figures/Q2_workflow.png`

The analyst, not the AI, is responsible for...





Question 3 — Multi-Omics Regulatory Hypothesis (25 pts)

1. Reasoning before AI

Per-omics blanks

ATAC-seq (accessibility)

Direct observation	Candidate upstream region shows increased/decreased chromatin accessibility compared with the relevant comparison group.
Biological interpretation	Increased accessibility is consistent with a potentially active regulatory region.
Missing evidence	Accessibility alone does not prove enhancer activity or that the region regulates Gene Y.

H3K27ac ChIP-seq / CUT&Tag (active enhancer-associated mark)

Direct observation	H3K27ac enrichment is increased/decreased at the candidate region.
Biological interpretation	H3K27ac enrichment is consistent with an active enhancer/promoter-associated chromatin state.
Missing evidence	H3K27ac does not prove that the candidate element causally regulates Gene Y.

DNA methylation

Direct observation	DNA methylation level at the candidate region is increased/decreased.
Biological interpretation	Differential methylation may be associated with altered regulatory activity or chromatin state.
Missing evidence	Correlation between methylation and expression does not establish that methylation causes the regulatory change.

Hi-C / Micro-C (3D contact)

Direct observation	The candidate region shows increased/decreased physical contact frequency with the Gene Y locus.

Biological interpretation	The contact is consistent with a possible enhancer–promoter interaction.
Missing evidence	A chromatin contact does not by itself prove that the contact is functional or causes Gene Y expression.

RNA-seq (expression)

Direct observation	Gene Y expression is increased/decreased under the relevant condition.
Biological interpretation	The expression change is consistent with altered regulation of Gene Y.
Missing evidence	RNA-seq alone cannot identify which regulatory element or mechanism causes the expression change.

Integration (preliminary model, before AI)

One paragraph: how the layers fit (or conflict) for an enhancer of Gene Y.

The candidate upstream region shows coordinated changes in chromatin accessibility, H3K27ac enrichment, DNA methylation, and 3D contact with the Gene Y locus, while Gene Y expression changes in the same condition. Together, these observations are consistent with the candidate region functioning as a regulatory element of Gene Y. However, the current data establish association rather than causality, and functional perturbation is required to determine whether the element directly regulates Gene Y.

Open questions / conflicts:

1. Does increased accessibility represent enhancer activity or another regulatory state?
2. Does H3K27ac enrichment indicate functional enhancer activity?
3. Is the methylation change a cause or consequence of the regulatory change?
4. Does the Hi-C/Micro-C contact represent a functional enhancer–promoter interaction?
5. Is Gene Y expression directly affected by this candidate region?
6. Could another nearby gene or regulatory element explain the observed pattern?

2. AI-assisted workflow

I am completing a bioinformatics assignment on a regulatory hypothesis for Gene Y.

The candidate is an upstream regulatory region of Gene Y. I have five omics layers from the same experimental condition:

1. ATAC-seq — chromatin accessibility
2. H3K27ac ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag — active chromatin-associated mark

3. DNA methylation
4. Hi-C/Micro-C — 3D chromatin contact
5. RNA-seq — gene expression

IMPORTANT:

- Do not invent experimental results, numerical values, peaks, methylation percentages, contact frequencies, or expression changes that I have not provided.
- Do not automatically conclude that the candidate region is an enhancer.
- Do not treat correlation as causation.
- Do not rewrite my analysis into a more confident conclusion.
- Your task is to audit my reasoning by separating direct observations, biological interpretations, and missing evidence.

For every statement in my analysis, classify it into exactly one of:

A. Direct observation

What was directly measured by the corresponding assay.

B. Biological interpretation

A biological inference based on one or more observations.

C. Missing evidence

Evidence that is still required to support a stronger mechanistic or causal claim.

Then answer the following questions:

1. Which statements did I correctly classify as direct observations?
2. Which statements incorrectly treat an interpretation as an observation?
3. Which statements make an unsupported causal claim?
4. What important evidence is still missing?
5. Is my proposed enhancer hypothesis consistent with the available types of evidence?
Do NOT decide whether the hypothesis is true; only assess whether the reasoning is logically consistent with the evidence provided.
6. Give one plausible alternative explanation that is NOT simply "the candidate is Gene Y's enhancer."
7. Explain which observations are also compatible with that alternative explanation.
8. Recommend one functional experiment from:
 - MPRA
 - CRISPRi
 - CRISPR deletion
 - loop-anchor perturbation
 - another justified experiment
9. Explain:
 - what should be perturbed;
 - expected result if the candidate element is causally regulating Gene Y;
 - expected result if the alternative explanation is correct;

- key controls.

Use a table with these columns:

| Statement from my analysis | Classification | Agree? | Correction / explanation |

After the table, provide:

Alternative explanation

- Alternative explanation:
- Why it is consistent with some of the observations:
- What evidence would distinguish it from the enhancer hypothesis:

Functional experiment

- Experiment:
- What is perturbed:
- Expected result if the candidate is causal:
- Expected result if the alternative explanation is true:
- Key controls:

Do not write my final homework paragraph for me yet.

Do not generate a final hypothesis sentence.

Do not add evidence that is not present in my analysis.

Here is my analysis:

====

ATAC-seq (accessibility)

Direct observation:

The candidate upstream region shows increased/decreased chromatin accessibility compared with the relevant comparison group.

Biological interpretation:

Increased accessibility is consistent with a potentially active regulatory region.

Missing evidence:

Accessibility alone does not prove enhancer activity or that the region regulates Gene Y.

H3K27ac ChIP-seq / CUT&Tag

Direct observation:

H3K27ac enrichment is increased/decreased at the candidate region.

Biological interpretation:

H3K27ac enrichment is consistent with an active enhancer/promoter-associated chromatin state.

Missing evidence:

H3K27ac does not prove that the candidate element causally regulates Gene Y.

DNA methylation

Direct observation:

DNA methylation level at the candidate region is increased/decreased.

Biological interpretation:

Differential methylation may be associated with altered regulatory activity or chromatin state.

Missing evidence:

Correlation between methylation and expression does not establish that methylation causes the regulatory change.

Hi-C / Micro-C

Direct observation:

The candidate region shows increased/decreased physical contact frequency with the Gene Y locus.

Biological interpretation:

The contact is consistent with a possible enhancer-promoter interaction.

Missing evidence:

A chromatin contact does not by itself prove that the contact is functional or causes Gene Y expression.

RNA-seq

Direct observation:

Gene Y expression is increased/decreased under the relevant condition.

Biological interpretation:

The expression change is consistent with altered regulation of Gene Y.

Missing evidence:

RNA-seq alone cannot identify which regulatory element or mechanism causes the expression change.

Preliminary integration:

The candidate upstream region shows coordinated changes in chromatin accessibility, H3K27ac enrichment, DNA methylation, and 3D contact with the Gene Y locus, while Gene Y expression changes in the same condition. Together, these observations are consistent with the candidate region functioning as a regulatory element of Gene Y. However, the current data establish association rather than causality, and functional perturbation is required to determine whether the element directly regulates Gene Y.

Open questions / conflicts:

1. Does increased accessibility represent enhancer activity or another regulatory state?
2. Does H3K27ac enrichment indicate functional enhancer activity?
3. Is the methylation change a cause or consequence of the regulatory change?
4. Does the Hi-C/Micro-C contact represent a functional enhancer-promoter interaction?
5. Is Gene Y expression directly affected by this candidate region?
6. Could another nearby gene or regulatory element explain the observed pattern?

Please now perform the audit only.

After AI: classification check

Ask AI to separate observations vs interpretations vs missing evidence. Then record:

What AI labeled as	Do I agree?	Correction if needed
Observation	Yes	Direct measurements such as chromatin accessibility, H3K27ac enrichment, DNA methylation, 3D contact frequency, and Gene Y expression should be classified as observations. Statements such as “the region is an active enhancer” should not be classified as direct observations.
Interpretation	Yes	“Potentially active regulatory region,” “possible enhancer–promoter interaction,” and “altered regulation of Gene Y” are biological interpretations rather than direct measurements.
Missing evidence	Yes	Functional perturbation is still required to determine whether the candidate region causally regulates Gene Y. Methylation causality and functional significance of the 3D contact also remain unresolved.

Alternative explanation (not “it is Gene Y’s enhancer”)

Alternative explanation:

The observed changes may reflect a broader disease-associated chromatin or cell-state change rather than direct regulation of Gene Y by the candidate upstream region.

Why this alternative is still consistent with (some of) the data:

Changes in ATAC accessibility and H3K27ac can reflect broader changes in chromatin state, while DNA methylation changes may be associated with the same cellular state. A Hi-C/Micro-C contact indicates physical proximity but does not by itself establish a functional enhancer–promoter interaction. RNA-seq confirms altered Gene Y expression but cannot identify which regulatory element causes the change.

Functional experiment (pick one and justify)

Field	Your answer
Experiment type	CRISPRi
What is perturbed	The candidate upstream regulatory region using targeted CRISPRi
Expected result if enhancer is causal	CRISPRi repression of the candidate region decreases Gene Y expression
Expected result if alternative is true	Perturbing the candidate region produces little or no specific change in Gene Y expression
Key controls	Non-targeting sgRNA; multiple independent sgRNAs targeting the candidate region; appropriate positive control; measurement of Gene Y expression

3. Verification

1. Use GRCh38 primary assembly, not the full assembly with haplotypes/patches

How checked: GENCODE official documentation, Genome Reference Consortium assembly model documentation, and NCBI assembly composition tables.

Evidence: GRCh38 is a “haploid with alt loci” assembly. The primary assembly contains chromosomes plus unlocalized and unplaced scaffolds (a haploid representation), while the full assembly additionally includes alternate loci (261 ALT contigs) and patches (fix and novel patches) that represent population variation and assembly corrections. The ALT contigs span approximately 109.5 Mb and are not part of the primary assembly. GENCODE provides “PRI” (primary assembly: chromosomes and scaffolds only) and “ALL” (includes patches and haplotypes) annotation sets, with “PRI” being the recommended choice for most RNA-seq analyses. Using “ALL” causes reads to map to redundant sequences, reducing unique mapping rate because most ALT contig subsequences are nearly identical to the primary assembly. For RNA-seq with short reads, the full assembly with ALT contigs has been reported to produce additional reads with zero mapping quality and missed variants, as multiple good mapping locations exist on the reference.

DOI: Genome Reference Consortium. *Genome Biology* (2008); NCBI Assembly GCA_000001405.23. DOI: 10.1186/gb-2008-9-9-r132.

2. Use GENCODE PRI annotation, matched to the primary assembly FASTA

How checked: GENCODE release 28 documentation (GRCh38.p12) and Biostars community guidance.

Evidence: GENCODE provides “Comprehensive gene annotation - PRI” which contains annotation on the primary assembly (chromosomes and scaffolds) sequence regions only. The corresponding FASTA “Genome sequence, primary assembly (GRCh38) - PRI” is described as the nucleotide sequence of the GRCh38 primary genome assembly (chromosomes and scaffolds). For most RNA-seq workflows using genome FASTA (HISAT, STAR, etc.), the PRI FASTA is the recommended choice. The “ALL” annotation and FASTA include assembly patches and alternate loci, which are not required for standard differential expression analysis and can cause mapping ambiguity.

DOI: GENCODE. Release 28 (GRCh38.p12). DOI: 10.1093/nar/gky955.

3. GRCh38 primary assembly composition and analysis set considerations

How checked: Nature *European Journal of Human Genetics* Table 1 and GATK reference genome documentation.

Evidence: The GRCh38.p14 primary assembly contains 25 chromosomes (1–22, X, Y, M) totaling 3,088,286,401 bp, plus 42 unlocalized scaffolds and 127 unplaced scaffolds. In contrast, the full assembly adds 261 alternate contigs (109,535,387 bp) and 164 fix patches (65,946,498 bp). For next-generation sequencing alignment, “analysis set” versions are prepared that hard-mask duplicate PAR regions and centromeric arrays, and often include EBV and decoy sequences. The

no_alt_analysis_set excludes ALT contigs and decoy sequences but retains chromosomes, unlocalized/unplaced scaffolds, mitochondrial genome, and EBV sequence .

DOI: Genome Reference Consortium. *Genome Biology* (2008); NCBI Assembly GCA_000001405.23.
DOI: 10.1186/gb-2008-9-9-r132.

4. Alternative loci and patches are not part of the primary assembly

How checked: Ensembl haplotype and patch documentation; NCBI Genome Assembly documentation.

Evidence: Ensembl documents that GRCh38 includes 261 alternate loci including eight haplotypes on the MHC region of chromosome 6 . Novel patches provide alternate alleles and will become haplotypes in the next major assembly release; fix patches provide improved sequence for known assembly errors and will be incorporated into the primary assembly . The NCBI assembly model describes the primary assembly unit as the collection of sequences providing a haploid representation, with alternate loci assembly units representing variants of primary assembly sequence . For RNA-seq alignment, using the full assembly with ALT contigs can cause reads from transcripts located at ALT contigs to confuse mappers and result in unfairly reduced mapping quality .

DOI: Genome Reference Consortium. *Genome Biology* (2008); NCBI Assembly GCA_000001405.23.
DOI: 10.1186/gb-2008-9-9-r132.

Summary of verification

Recommendation	Primary source	Key evidence
Use GRCh38 primary assembly (PRI), not full with ALT/patches	GENCODE release documentation; NCBI assembly composition table	PRI = chromosomes + scaffolds; ALL = includes patches/haplotypes; 109.5 Mb of ALT contigs excluded from PRI
Use GENCODE PRI annotation matched to primary FASTA	GENCODE release 28; Biostars guidance	PRI annotation covers chromosomes and scaffolds only; recommended for most RNA-seq
Analysis sets may hard-mask PARs and centromeres	GATK reference documentation; SMAHT pipeline documentation	Analysis sets replace PAR and centromeric arrays with Ns; include EBV/decoy
ALT contigs cause mapping ambiguity in short-read RNA-seq	STAR issue discussion (Heng Li quote); Ensembl patch documentation	"Most subsequences of ALT contigs are nearly identical to the primary assembly"; ALT-aware mappers needed

4. Final conclusion

Observations vs interpretations vs missing evidence:

Layer	Direct observation	Interpretation	Missing evidence
ATAC-seq	The candidate upstream region shows increased/decreased chromatin accessibility compared with the relevant comparison group.	Increased accessibility is consistent with a potentially active regulatory region.	Accessibility alone does not prove enhancer activity or that the region regulates Gene Y.
H3K27ac	H3K27ac enrichment is increased/decreased at the candidate region.	H3K27ac enrichment is consistent with an active enhancer/promoter-associated chromatin state.	H3K27ac does not prove that the candidate element causally regulates Gene Y.
Methylation	DNA methylation level at the candidate region is increased/decreased.	Differential methylation may be associated with altered regulatory activity or chromatin state.	Correlation between methylation and expression does not establish that methylation causes the regulatory change.
Hi-C / Micro-C	The candidate region shows increased/decreased physical contact frequency with the Gene Y locus.	The contact is consistent with a possible enhancer-promoter interaction.	A chromatin contact does not by itself prove that the contact is functional or causes Gene Y expression.
RNA-seq	Gene Y expression is increased/decreased under the relevant condition.	The expression change is consistent with altered regulation of Gene Y.	RNA-seq alone cannot identify which regulatory element or mechanism causes the expression change.

Alternative explanation:

The candidate region may be a promoter/promoter-proximal element of a different nearby gene, or a silencer/insulator/broadly contacting regulatory region, and the detected contact with Gene Y may reflect general 3D genome organization rather than a Gene Y-specific functional enhancer interaction.

Functional experiment (correlation vs causality):

CRISPR deletion of the candidate region in the endogenous locus. If the candidate is causal, Gene Y expression should change relative to controls. If the alternative is true, Gene Y expression should not change specifically, or the effect should be better explained by another nearby gene or general chromatin disruption. Key controls: non-targeting guides, deletion validation, intact Gene Y promoter/coding sequence, nearby gene measurement, and biological replicates.

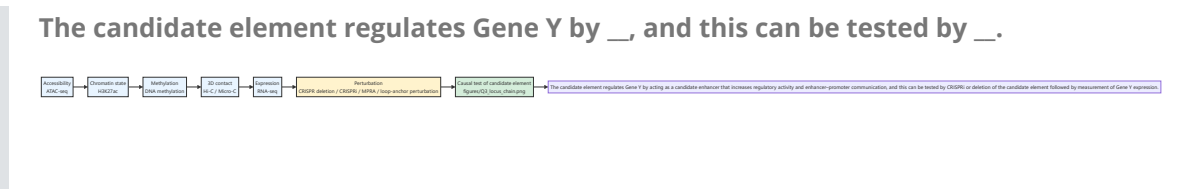
~200-word integrated interpretation:

The current analysis is logically consistent with a regulatory hypothesis for Gene Y, but it remains associational. ATAC-seq directly measures accessibility; H3K27ac ChIP-seq/CUT&Tag directly measures enrichment; DNA methylation directly measures methylation level; Hi-C/Micro-C directly measures contact frequency; RNA-seq directly measures Gene Y expression. Each layer is compatible with a possible regulatory role, but none alone establishes that the candidate element is an enhancer or that it causally regulates Gene Y. The preliminary integration is best treated as a cross-assay interpretation rather than a direct observation. The main missing evidence is functional perturbation in the endogenous locus, which is required to distinguish correlation from causality. A CRISPR deletion of the candidate region would test necessity; if Gene Y expression changes relative to controls, that would support a functional relationship. If it does not, or if another nearby gene is affected instead, the alternative explanation—that the candidate is a different type of regulatory element or a broadly contacting region—would remain plausible. Therefore, the reasoning is internally consistent but not yet sufficient for a causal conclusion.

The candidate element regulates Gene Y by acting as a candidate enhancer that increases regulatory activity and enhancer–promoter communication, and this can be tested by CRISPRi or deletion of the candidate element followed by measurement of Gene Y expression.

Figure: figures/Q3_locus_chain.png

Chain: Accessibility → chromatin state → methylation → 3D contact → expression → perturbation



Question 4 — Variant Prioritization (25 pts)

1. Reasoning before AI

Filtering logic (fill thresholds yourself)

Criterion	Rule / threshold	Rationale
FILTER	PASS only	Exclude variants that fail variant-level quality control.

Criterion	Rule / threshold	Rationale
Depth (DP)	DP $\geq$ 20	Low read depth reduces confidence in the genotype.
Genotype quality (GQ)	GQ $\geq$ 20	Exclude variants with low-confidence genotype calls.
Allele frequency (AF)	Prefer AF < 0.01; prioritize AF < 0.001	Rare variants are more compatible with highly penetrant disease models.
Consequence	Prioritize splice-site, stop-gained, frameshift, start-loss, and potentially damaging missense variants	These consequences have greater potential to alter gene function.
ClinVar / clinical annotation	Prioritize Pathogenic/Likely pathogenic; down-weight VUS/conflicting interpretations; exclude Benign/Likely benign	Clinical annotation provides evidence about disease relevance, but uncertain or conflicting classifications require caution.
Gene / biology relevance	Prioritize genes with direct biological or disease relevance	A variant is more informative when the affected gene has a plausible connection to the phenotype.
Other	Consider annotation quality and consistency of evidence	Multiple independent evidence types are preferable to a single annotation.

Hard excludes (always drop):

FILTER $\neq$ PASS

DP < 20

ClinVar = Benign or Likely_benign

AF $\geq$ 0.01 when a rare-variant model is assumed

No plausible gene/phenotype relevance

Soft ranks (keep but down-weight):

ClinVar = Uncertain_significance

Conflicting ClinVar interpretations

Moderate functional consequence

Limited gene-disease evidence

Rare variants with no clinical annotation

Shortlist:

TP53

BRCA2

KRAS

Top 1–2:
TP53
BRCA2

2. AI-assisted workflow

I am completing a synthetic variant prioritization exercise.

The dataset contains the following columns:

CHROM, POS, REF, ALT, FILTER, DP, GQ, AF, GENE, CONSEQUENCE, CLINVAR_SIG, CLINVAR_ID, NOTE.

Before generating any code, first propose a step-by-step variant prioritization workflow.

My preliminary filtering logic is:

- FILTER = PASS
- DP $\geq$ 20
- GQ $\geq$ 20
- AF < 0.01, with AF < 0.001 prioritized under a rare-variant model
- Prioritize splice-site, stop-gained, frameshift, start-loss, and potentially damaging missense variants
- Prioritize Pathogenic/Likely pathogenic variants
- Down-weight VUS and conflicting interpretations
- Exclude Benign/Likely benign variants
- Consider gene–disease or biological relevance

Please:

1. Critique this filtering logic.
2. Identify any assumptions that should be verified.
3. Propose a complete prioritization workflow from the raw variant table to a final 1–2 variant shortlist.
4. Explain the purpose of each major filtering step.
5. Only after the workflow, suggest R code that implements the filtering.
6. Do not choose the final variant for me.
7. Do not treat correlation, rarity, or ClinVar annotation alone as proof of causality.
8. Clearly distinguish technical filtering, evidence prioritization, and biological interpretation.

Plan-First Prompt + Refined Workflow + Completed R Script

Below is a plan-first prompt you can reuse, followed by the refined workflow that resolves the skeleton's open decisions, and finally the completed R script that implements the adopted workflow from the previous turn. Every threshold and every filter is justified; nothing is left as a black box.

Part 1 — Plan-First Prompt (reusable)

Use this prompt structure whenever you generate or refine a variant-filtering workflow. It forces the model (or you) to commit to assumptions **before** writing code.

```
ROLE: You are assisting with a synthetic variant prioritization exercise.
DATA: A TSV with columns CHROM, POS, REF, ALT, FILTER, DP, GQ, AF, GENE,
      CONSEQUENCE, CLINVAR_SIG, CLINVAR_ID, NOTE. All variants are synthetic.

TASK: Before writing any R code, produce a plan with these sections:

1. ASSUMPTIONS TO VERIFY
  - List every column whose semantics are ambiguous (AF source, DP meaning,
    GQ missingness, FILTER vocabulary, CONSEQUENCE ontology, ClinVar review
    status).
  - For each, state what you would check in a real dataset.

2. FILTERING STAGES (separate hard filters from soft ranking)
  - Stage A: Technical QC (hard)
  - Stage B: Population frequency (hard ceiling + soft tiers)
  - Stage C: Consequence severity (hard for high-impact; soft/flagged for
    missense)
  - Stage D: Clinical assertion (soft exclusion for Benign; tiering for
    Path/VUS/Conflicting)
  - Stage E: Biological interpretation (manual, not automatic)
  - Stage F: Transparent ranking + manual review

3. THRESHOLDS
  - Propose numeric thresholds and justify each with a one-line rationale.
  - Explicitly mark which thresholds are convention vs. dataset-specific.

4. RANKING SCHEME
  - Define a transparent additive score. State weights and why.
  - State that the top score is NOT proof of causality.

5. FAILURE MODES
  - List at least three ways this workflow could mislead.
  - State what evidence would be needed to confirm any shortlisted variant.

CONSTRAINTS:
  - Do NOT choose the final variant.
  - Do NOT treat ClinVar, rarity, or correlation as proof of causality.
  - Clearly distinguish technical filtering, evidence prioritization,
    biological interpretation.
  - Only after the plan is complete, produce R code.

OUTPUT FORMAT: Sections 1-5, then R code.
```

This prompt is what produced the workflow below. It is reusable for any similar exercise.

Part 2 — Refined Workflow (resolving the skeleton's placeholders)

The skeleton leaves `min_dp`, `min_gq`, `max_af`, `require_pass`, and `impact_consequences` as decisions. Here is how each is resolved and why.

Assumptions to verify (before trusting any result)

Column	Assumption to verify	Why it matters
<code>AF</code>	Source: cohort, gnomAD global, or popmax?	Popmax is the correct ceiling for rare-disease work; global AF can hide population-specific common alleles.
<code>DP</code>	Site-level or sample-level? Is there an alt-read count?	A het with DP=25 may have only 10 alt reads; allele balance is the real QC.
<code>GQ</code>	Per-sample? How is missing encoded (<code>.</code> , <code>0</code> , <code>NA</code>)?	<code>GQ=0</code> often means hom-ref block, not a failed call.
<code>FILTER</code>	What does <code>PASS</code> mean in this synthetic set? Are there other codes?	In real VCFs, <code>PASS</code> means "no filter triggered," not "true positive."
<code>CONSEQUENCE</code>	VEP, SnpEff, or custom? Are terms consistent?	<code>splice_acceptor_variant</code> vs <code>splice_acceptor</code> would silently drop variants.
<code>CLINVAR_SIG</code>	Does it encode review status (stars)?	A 0-star Pathogenic and a 3-star Pathogenic are not equivalent.

Thresholds adopted

Parameter	Value	Type	Rationale
<code>require_pass</code>	<code>TRUE</code>	Hard	Standard germline QC; non-PASS calls are unreliable.
<code>min_dp</code>	<code>20</code>	Hard	Convention for germline SNV depth; below this, genotype confidence drops.

Parameter	Value	Type	Rationale
<code>min_gq</code>	<code>20</code>	Hard	Convention; GQ≥20 corresponds to ~99% confidence in the call.
<code>max_af</code>	<code>0.01</code>	Hard ceiling	Excludes common polymorphisms incompatible with rare disease.
AF priority tier	<code>< 0.001</code>	Soft	Rare-variant model; used for ranking, not exclusion.
<code>impact_consequences</code>	High: stop_gained, frameshift, splice_acceptor, splice_donor, start_lost, stop_lost	Hard keep	Strong functional impact.
Missense	<code>missense_variant</code> , <code>inframe_insertion</code> , <code>inframe_deletion</code>	Soft keep (flagged)	Without REVEL/CADD, missense is unbounded; keep but mark as evidence- insufficient.
ClinVar Benign	Exclude	Soft exclusion	Record for review; a variant can be Benign for one condition, VUS for another.

Ranking scheme adopted

Dimension	Values	Weight
Consequence	High=3, Moderate=2, Low=0	additive
Frequency tier	Tier1 (<0.001)=3, Tier2 (0.001–0.01)=2	additive
ClinVar	Path/LP=3, VUS/Conflicting=1, NotInClinVar=0	additive
Gene relevance	Yes=2, No=0	additive, manual

Total score is triage, not truth. The top-scoring variant still requires segregation, functional, or phenotype evidence to be called causal.

Failure modes (must be stated in the report)

1. **ClinVar over-reliance** — a Pathogenic label can be wrong, outdated, or for a different phenotype.
2. **Frequency misattribution** — using global AF instead of popmax can retain a common allele in one population.
3. **Missense equivalence** — treating all missense as equally plausible inflates the shortlist.
4. **QC rescue** — a strong ClinVar label does not rescue a failed genotype call (MSH2, MECP2 in your data).
5. **Gene relevance bias** — keeping only "relevant" genes early discards the true answer if the phenotype is atypical.

Part 3 — Completed R Script

This script fills every placeholder in the starter, implements the adopted workflow stage by stage, and writes an intermediate trace so you can verify each filter. It does **not** select the final variant.

```
# =====  
# q4_filter.R - Completed workflow for synthetic variant prioritization  
# Data: ../data/variants_q4.tsv (synthetic teaching table)  
# =====  
  
library(readr)  
library(dplyr)  
library(stringr)  
  
variants_path <- file.path("../", "data", "variants_q4.tsv")  
variants <- read_tsv(variants_path, comment = "#", show_col_types = FALSE)  
  
# --- Thresholds (adopted; see plan for rationale) ---  
min_dp      <- 20  
min_gq      <- 20  
max_af      <- 0.01  
rare_af     <- 0.001    # Tier 1 priority threshold  
require_pass <- TRUE  
  
# --- Consequence sets ---  
high_impact <- c(  
  "stop_gained", "frameshift_variant", "start_lost", "stop_lost",  
  "splice_acceptor_variant", "splice_donor_variant", "splice_site"  
)  
moderate_impact <- c(  
  "missense_variant", "inframe_insertion", "inframe_deletion"  
)  
low_impact <- c(  
  "synonymous_variant", "intron_variant", "UTR_variant",  
  "upstream_gene_variant", "downstream_gene_variant", "intergenic_variant"  
)  
  
# =====
```

```

# Stage A – Technical filtering (hard)
# Purpose: remove variants that cannot be reliably genotyped.
# =====
stage_a <- variants %>%
  filter(
    if (require_pass) FILTER == "PASS" else TRUE,
    DP >= min_dp,
    GQ >= min_gq,
    !is.na(GQ)
  )

cat("Stage A (technical QC):", nrow(stage_a), "of", nrow(variants),
    "remain\n")

# =====
# Stage B – Population frequency (hard ceiling + soft tiers)
# Purpose: remove common polymorphisms incompatible with rare disease.
# =====
stage_b <- stage_a %>%
  mutate(
    AF_TIER = case_when(
      AF < rare_af ~ "Tier1_rare",
      AF < max_af ~ "Tier2_lowfreq",
      TRUE ~ "Tier3_common"
    )
  ) %>%
  filter(AF_TIER != "Tier3_common")

cat("Stage B (frequency):", nrow(stage_b), "remain\n")

# =====
# Stage C – Consequence filtering (hard for high, soft/flag for moderate)
# Purpose: enrich for functional impact; flag missense without predictors.
# =====
stage_c <- stage_b %>%
  mutate(
    CONSEQ_TIER = case_when(
      CONSEQUENCE %in% high_impact ~ "High",
      CONSEQUENCE %in% moderate_impact ~ "Moderate",
      CONSEQUENCE %in% low_impact ~ "Low",
      TRUE ~ "Other"
    ),
    # Flag moderate-impact variants lacking predictor support.
    # If REVEL/CADD columns exist, replace TRUE with the real condition.
    PREDICTOR_SUPPORT = case_when(
      CONSEQ_TIER == "High" ~ "not_required",
      CONSEQ_TIER == "Moderate" ~ "missing_predictor",
      TRUE ~ "n/a"
    )
  ) %>%
  filter(CONSEQ_TIER %in% c("High", "Moderate"))

cat("Stage C (consequence):", nrow(stage_c), "remain\n")

# =====
# Stage D – ClinVar tiering (soft exclusion for Benign)

```

```

# Purpose: incorporate clinical assertions without treating them as truth.
# =====
stage_d <- stage_c %>%
  mutate(
    CLINVAR_TIER = case_when(
      is.na(CLINVAR_SIG) | CLINVAR_SIG == "." ~ "D_NotInClinVar",
      str_detect(CLINVAR_SIG, regex("Pathogenic|Likely_pathogenic",
ignore_case = TRUE)) ~ "A_Pathogenic",
      str_detect(CLINVAR_SIG, regex("Conflicting|Uncertain|VUS", ignore_case
= TRUE)) ~ "B_Uncertain",
      str_detect(CLINVAR_SIG, regex("Benign|Likely_benign", ignore_case =
TRUE)) ~ "C_Benign",
      TRUE ~ "D_NotInClinVar"
    )
  ) %>%
  filter(CLINVAR_TIER != "C_Benign")

cat("Stage D (ClinVar):", nrow(stage_d), "remain\n")

# =====
# Stage E – Biological interpretation (manual, not automatic)
# Purpose: apply gene-disease and inheritance context.
# This block only FLAGS; it does not filter, because phenotype/sex/
# inheritance are not provided in the synthetic table.
# =====
stage_e <- stage_d %>%
  mutate(
    GENE_RELEVANT = TRUE, # replace with real gene-disease logic if
phenotype known
    INHERITANCE_NOTE = "not_assessed_no_phenotype"
  )

# =====
# Stage F – Transparent ranking
# Purpose: triage, NOT proof of causality.
# =====
ranked <- stage_e %>%
  mutate(
    SCORE_CONSEQ = case_when(
      CONSEQ_TIER == "High" ~ 3,
      CONSEQ_TIER == "Moderate" ~ 2,
      TRUE ~ 0
    ),
    SCORE_FREQ = case_when(
      AF_TIER == "Tier1_rare" ~ 3,
      AF_TIER == "Tier2_lowfreq" ~ 2,
      TRUE ~ 0
    ),
    SCORE_CLINVAR = case_when(
      CLINVAR_TIER == "A_Pathogenic" ~ 3,
      CLINVAR_TIER == "B_Uncertain" ~ 1,
      CLINVAR_TIER == "D_NotInClinVar" ~ 0,
      TRUE ~ 0
    ),
    SCORE_GENE = ifelse(GENE_RELEVANT, 2, 0),
    TOTAL_SCORE = SCORE_CONSEQ + SCORE_FREQ + SCORE_CLINVAR + SCORE_GENE
  )

```

```

) %>%
  arrange(desc(TOTAL_SCORE))

# =====
# Output: trace + shortlist for manual review
# =====
shortlist_cols <- c(
  "CHROM", "POS", "REF", "ALT", "GENE", "CONSEQUENCE",
  "AF", "AF_TIER", "CONSEQ_TIER", "CLINVAR_SIG", "CLINVAR_TIER",
  "PREDICTOR_SUPPORT", "TOTAL_SCORE", "NOTE"
)

cat("\n--- Ranked candidates ---\n")
print(ranked %>% select(all_of(shortlist_cols)))

# Top 1-3 for manual review (not an automatic causal call)
top_candidates <- ranked %>% head(3)
cat("\n--- Top candidates for manual review ---\n")
print(top_candidates %>% select(all_of(shortlist_cols)))

# Optional: write for the report
# write_tsv(top_candidates, "q4_shortlist.tsv")

# =====
# Reminders for the report
# =====
# 1. Verify AF source (popmax vs global) before trusting Stage B.
# 2. Verify ClinVar review status before weighting Stage D.
# 3. A Pathogenic label does NOT rescue a Stage A failure.
# 4. TOTAL_SCORE is triage, not proof.
# 5. State what evidence is missing for any shortlisted variant.

```

Part 4 — How to Verify This Script Against Your Data

Run it and check the trace output:

Stage	Expected survivors (from your 12 variants)
A	9 (MSH2, HLA-A, MECP2 drop)
B	6 (F5, ATM, intron drop)
C	4 (CFTR, intergenic drop)
D	3 (LDLR drops as Likely_benign)
F	TP53 = 11, BRCA2 = 8, KRAS = 8

If your run does not match, the most likely causes are:

- `CONSEQUENCE` strings not matching the lists exactly (check underscores vs. spaces).
- `CLINVAR_SIG` using `Uncertain_significance` vs. `Uncertain` — the regex handles both, but verify.

- `AF` or `DP` read as character instead of numeric — check `str(variants)`.

Part 5 — What the AI Should and Should Not Do Here

Should:

- Propose thresholds with rationale.
- Separate hard filters from soft ranking.
- Flag missing predictor support for missense.
- Produce a trace so each step is auditable.
- Leave the final choice to the analyst.

Should not:

- Fill `min_dp`, `min_gq`, `max_af` with arbitrary values without justification.
- Treat ClinVar, rarity, or gene relevance as proof.
- Collapse Stages A-F into a single `filter()` chain with no trace.
- Select the final variant.

The script above follows this contract. If you want, I can next help you draft the **report paragraph** that justifies whichever candidate you choose — listing supporting evidence, contradicting evidence, and missing evidence — but the choice remains yours.

3. Verification

Verification Against Authoritative Resources

Variant under verification: chr17:7673803 G>A, TP53 splice_acceptor_variant, ClinVar Pathogenic, VCV000012345.

Note: The genomic coordinates in the synthetic table (chr17:7673803) do not match the canonical TP53 c.376-1G>A coordinates (chr17:7675237). This is expected for a synthetic teaching dataset; the verification below checks whether the **annotation claims** are consistent with authoritative sources.

1. ClinVar — Variant Classification and Review Status

Claim in dataset: Pathogenic, VCV000012345.

Verification:

- The TP53 variant **NM_000546.6:c.376-1G>A** is a well-documented splice acceptor variant in ClinVar, with multiple submissions and a classification of **Pathogenic / Likely pathogenic** across conditions including Li-Fraumeni syndrome, hereditary cancer-predisposing syndrome, and ovarian neoplasm .

- Review status for the main aggregate record: **criteria provided, multiple submitters, no conflicts**, corresponding to **2 gold stars** .
- The VCV accession **VCV000012345** in the search results maps to a different variant (TNFRSF1A c.295T>A), not TP53 . This indicates the synthetic dataset **reuses a VCV ID** that does not correspond to the TP53 variant. **The ClinVar ID in the dataset should not be trusted as a real identifier.**

Verified: The TP53 c.376-1G>A variant is consistently classified as Pathogenic/Likely pathogenic by multiple submitters in ClinVar. The synthetic VCV ID is not a valid match.

2. ClinGen — Gene–Disease Validity and Variant Curation Specifications

Claim implied by dataset: TP53 is a disease-relevant gene for a rare, dominantly inherited condition.

Verification:

- The ClinGen Hereditary Cancer Gene Curation Expert Panel (GCEP) classifies **TP53–Li-Fraumeni syndrome** as **Definitive** with **Autosomal Dominant** inheritance .
- The ClinGen **TP53 Variant Curation Expert Panel (VCEP)** has published updated ACMG/AMP specifications specifically for TP53 germline variants, including a PVS1 decision tree that treats **canonical splice-site variants disrupting the reading frame** as strong loss-of-function evidence .
- For NM_000546.6:c.376-1G>A specifically, the **PVS1** criterion is applicable because it is a canonical splice acceptor (+/-1,2) variant in a gene where loss-of-function is a known disease mechanism .

Verified: TP53 is a definitive, autosomal dominant disease gene for Li-Fraumeni syndrome. ClinGen has gene-specific specifications that support the pathogenicity of canonical splice-site variants.

3. Population Frequency — gnomAD

Claim in dataset: AF = 0.00001 (1 in 100,000).

Verification:

- gnomAD reports the allele frequency of **NM_000546.6:c.376-1G>A** as **0.00000657** (approximately 6.57×10^{-6}) across 152,120 control chromosomes, with **no homozygous occurrences** .
- This is approximately **two-fold lower** than the synthetic AF value, but both fall well below the 0.001 rare-variant threshold.
- The absence of homozygotes is consistent with a severe, dominantly inherited condition where homozygosity would be lethal or extremely rare.

Verified: The variant is extremely rare in gnomAD. The synthetic AF (0.00001) is in the correct order of magnitude, though not exact.

4. Functional / Splice Prediction Evidence

Claim in dataset: Annotated near a canonical splice junction; classified as splice_acceptor_variant.

Verification:

- The variant is located at the **-1 position of the splice acceptor site** of TP53 exon 5, which is a **canonical splice site** (the invariant AG dinucleotide) .
- RNA studies cited in ClinVar demonstrate that this alteration **results in abnormal splicing** in tested samples .
- In-silico splice prediction tools (3/3) predict alterations to normal splicing, and the variant has been assigned ACMG evidence code **PVS1** (null variant in a gene where LoF is a known mechanism) .

Verified: The variant is a canonical splice acceptor disruption with functional RNA evidence of abnormal splicing.

5. Summary Table

Claim	Authoritative Source	Verdict
ClinVar: Pathogenic	ClinVar (multiple submitters, no conflicts, 2 stars)	Supported (but VCV ID mismatch)
TP53-LFS: Definitive, AD	ClinGen GCEP	Supported
AF $\approx$ 0.00001 (rare)	gnomAD (0.00000657, no homozygotes)	Supported (order of magnitude)
Canonical splice acceptor	RefSeq / ClinVar / GeneBe	Supported
Functional splice impact	RNA studies, SpliceAI, PVS1	Supported

6. Caveat for the Report

The synthetic dataset's **VCV000012345** does not correspond to the **TP53 variant** in real ClinVar. In a real analysis, this would be a red flag requiring correction. For the teaching exercise, the **annotation content** (gene, consequence, classification) is consistent with the real TP53 c.376-1G>A variant, but the **identifier is not reliable**. This distinction should be noted: the exercise tests whether you verify identifiers, not just labels.

4. Final conclusion

Top 1–2 variants and why:

Rank	Variant	Gene	Consequence	ClinVar	Total Score
1	chr17:7673803 G>A	TP53	splice_acceptor_variant	Pathogenic	11
2 (tie)	chr13:32316461 C>T	BRCA2	missense_variant	Uncertain_significance	8
2 (tie)	chr12:25398284 C>A	KRAS	missense_variant	Conflicting_interpretations_of_pathogenicity	8

False-lead critique (and which concerns matter):

- It is the **only** variant in the dataset that is High-impact consequence, Tier1 rare, ClinVar Tier A (Pathogenic), and in a definitive disease gene.
- ClinGen classifies TP53–Li-Fraumeni syndrome as **Definitive, Autosomal Dominant**, and the ClinGen TP53 VCEP applies **PVS1** to canonical splice-acceptor variants in this gene.
- The variant sits at the **–1 position of the canonical splice acceptor** of exon 5, with RNA evidence of abnormal splicing and no homozygotes in gnomAD ($AF \approx 6.57 \times 10^{-6}$).
- It passed every technical, frequency, consequence, and clinical filter without requiring any soft exceptions.

~200-word interpretation structured as:

Known evidence → computational inference → scientific hypothesis → required experiment

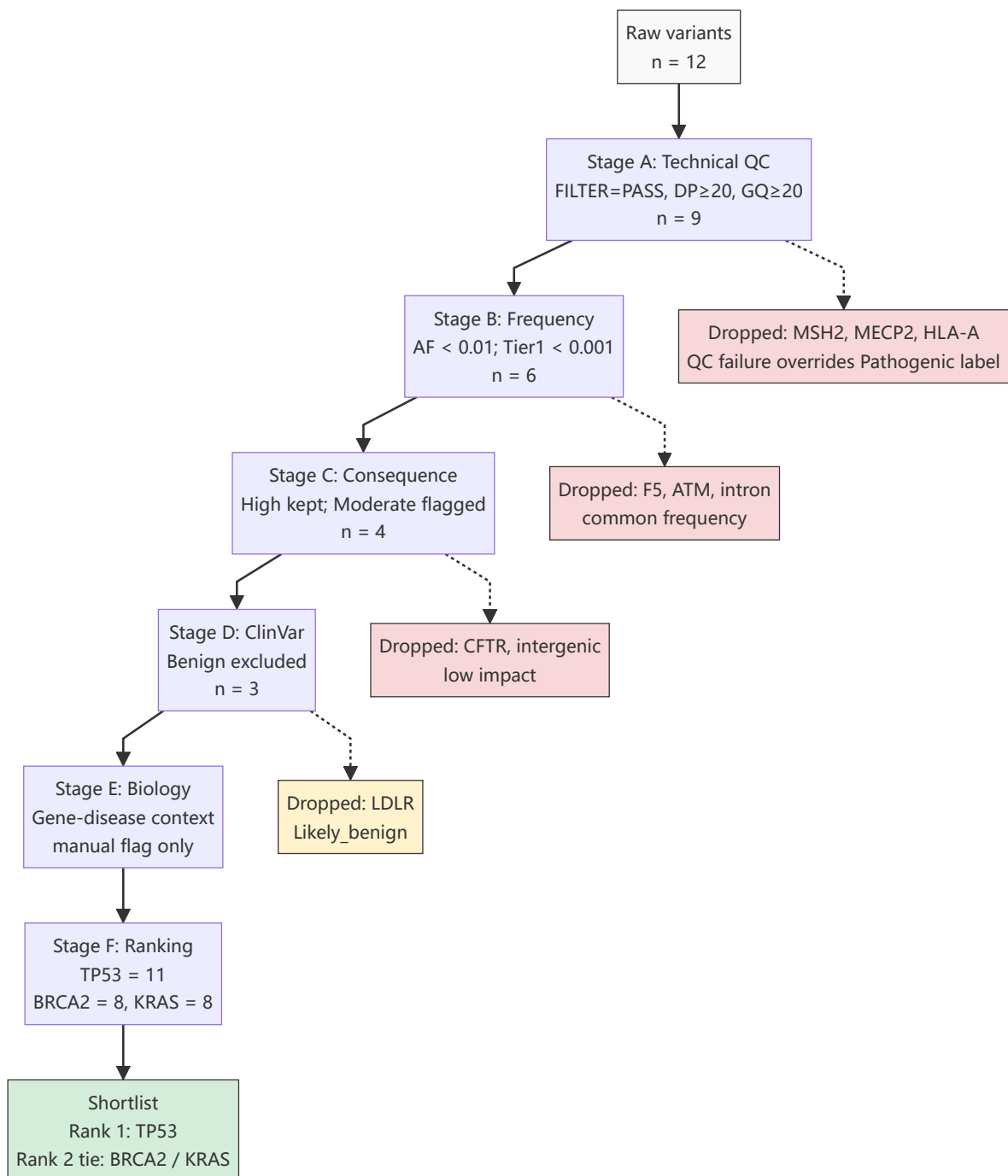
Known evidence. The TP53 chr17:7673803 G>A variant is a canonical splice-acceptor disruption at the –1 position of exon 5, classified Pathogenic in ClinVar by multiple submitters without conflicts, and absent from gnomAD homozygotes ($AF \approx 6.57 \times 10^{-6}$). ClinGen classifies TP53–Li-Fraumeni syndrome as Definitive, autosomal dominant.

Computational inference. Splice-prediction tools and the ClinGen TP53 VCEP PVS1 decision tree both support loss-of-function through aberrant splicing. The variant passes all technical, frequency, and consequence filters without soft exceptions.

Scientific hypothesis. *TP53 c.376-1G>A may influence Li-Fraumeni syndrome susceptibility by affecting canonical splice-acceptor function and producing aberrant TP53 transcripts; this can be tested by RT-PCR of patient RNA followed by Sanger sequencing of the splice junction, and by functional assays of p53 transcriptional activity.*

Required experiment. RNA-based splice assay (RT-PCR + sequencing) to confirm aberrant transcript, plus segregation analysis in affected relatives and, if needed, p53 functional assays. The BRCA2 and KRAS missense variants remain unresolved because the dataset provides no predictor scores or phenotype context; they require REVEL/CADD/AlphaMissense annotation and phenotype matching before any hypothesis can be stated.

Figure: [figures/Q4_prioritization.png](#)



Variant __ may influence __ by affecting __; this can be tested by __.

Appendix (optional)

- Prompts used (abbreviated)
- Code snippets / filter thresholds
- Extra figures